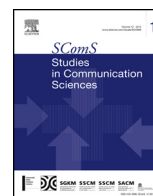




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Online representation of Switzerland as a tourism destination: An exploratory research on a Chinese microblogging platform

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ABSTRACT

This research explores how tourism-related user-generated content is distributed by topics with reference to the online image of Switzerland as a tourism destination. Main goal of this study is to investigate online representation of Switzerland by Chinese travelers. Results show that the most mentioned topics in the Chinese microblogging platform are tourism related products and services. Chinese tourists express that the destination offers a pleasant atmosphere and a satisfying tourism experience. Moreover, people express their desire to visit Switzerland, discuss stories they heard from others about traveling to this country, and share information sources about Switzerland from third parties' blogs or websites.

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1. Introduction

Tourism communication is a strategic tool, which combines communication techniques, marketing concepts, available information about the place to visit (e.g. tourism destination) and the hospitality services this place is offering (Boyer & Viallon, 1994).

In the last decade, tourism industry has been facing an intensive shift in a global context due to the communication and marketing opportunities offered by Information and Communication Technologies (ICTs). For instance, tourism destinations were given an opportunity to use online communication channels for their promotional activities globally. Additionally, ICTs allowed the generation of electronic word-of-mouth, which in turn gathers countless online discourses. These discourses are becoming more influential than official sources in the decision making to visit destination by prospective travelers (Inversini, Cantoni, & Buhalis, 2009; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). Such discourses can be found online in the form of user-generated contents (UGCs), such as travel blogs, travel review websites, and virtual communities, and might be analyzed as efficient sources of information for the investigation of the online representation of different objects, for instance tourism destinations.

Moreover, online discourses might contribute to the formation of the online representation of a tourism destination, leveraging what other people perceive and write about the destination in the online context (Govers & Go, 2009; Marchiori, Cantoni, & Fesenmaier, 2013). A pleasant travel experience, full of enjoyable images, which is reported in a blog or depicted in a photo album shared online might draw an attractive profile of a tourism destination. Vice versa, a post in a discussion forum talking about a negative encounter/experience at a destination might depict the destination a blemished portrayal. In this online communication environment, tourism managers in charge of promotion might receive an added value and an important input from the understanding of the online representation of their destination by the demand side—current or potential tourists. Indeed, the attractiveness of a destination and the way it is depicted in online discourses can affect the decision of a potential tourist to visit one or another touristic location. Tourism managers can gather factual data (e.g. reported experiences and opinions) of tourists' perceptions about their destinations, and infer strengths and limits, so to refine and enhance their marketing strategies.

In this research, one destination has been chosen as a case study for the investigation of online discourses' topics covered in online media. Switzerland, as a prospective place to be visited, and Chinese-speaking web users, as prospective visitors, will be analyzed in this study.

Mainland China has been remarked as a prospect market of outbound tourism with great potentialities as the Chinese population is getting affluent, and a growing number of them can afford to

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travel abroad (Li, Harrill, Uvsal, Burnett, & Zhan, 2010; Sparks & Pan, 2009). Meanwhile, the behavior of Chinese traveling to foreign places in general and Western Europe in particular has only recently started to be looked by tourism researchers (Cochrane, 2008; Prayag, Cohen, & Yan, 2013; Sparks & Pan, 2009).

According to a recent survey by Ctrip.com (Xinhua, 2012a, 2012b), in 2012 Switzerland tops the list as the most desirable European destinations among Chinese travelers. The results of the survey showed that 80% of respondents aged between 20 and 45 wanted to travel to Switzerland, as a top choice among other European countries including France, Greece, Germany, Austria, the United Kingdom, and Ireland. This trend has been found also in the report of Swiss authorities (FSO, 2011), which suggests that the overnight stay by Chinese visitors' (excluding Hong Kong) in Switzerland grew strongly in 2009 (+26.8%), with a prediction of strong continuation in the years to come. Moreover, Chinese travelers are very active online both in terms of searching travel-related information, and sharing travel experiences after their trips (Thraenhart, 2011). Recent reports released by China Travel Trends, China Outbound Tourism Research Institute, and Asia Pacific Travel Association state that Chinese travelers are more likely to get their information through social media, rather than visiting official websites. Among all types of social networks in Mainland China, microblog is gaining considerable popularity. More than a half of the Internet users, specifically 50.9% (274 million), use microblog, also known as Weibo in Chinese. The scale of overall microblog users had a burst of growing speed during 2011, and now steps into a high level utilization. It has been also highlighted that the utilization ratio of using mobile for microblogging keeps growing among mobile internet users, presenting the highest growth rate among all the mobile applications, and rises to 43.8% (CINIC, 2012).

Considering the abovementioned scenario, following mutual interests between Chinese tourists and their desired destination: Switzerland, also considering the popularity of the microblog in mainland China, as well as taking into consideration the research gap identified within this topic, an interesting convergence appears. Therefore, authors could define the following research question: *What are the covered topics about Switzerland as a tourism destination on a Chinese microblogging platform?*

Within this study, topics extracted from the microblog posts will be explored, together with the sentiment expressed through each microblog post.

2. Literature review

2.1. User-generated contents and tourism destinations

According to Blackshaw and Nazzaro (2006, p. 4), user-generated-content (UGC) is "a mixture of fact and opinion, impression and sentiment, founded and unfounded tidbits, experiences, and even rumors". People express their opinions and narrate their experiences, these opinions are published in the online environment, then aggregated and indexed and could be seen by a number of people, thus providing mediated experiences to other users. Major part of tourism-related UGCs are representations of tourists' experiences, which present feelings and judgments about a certain tourism topic and might have an impact, being it positive or negative, onto how the destination is perceived by others. Tourism related UGCs can influence travel decision-making process of other potential tourists (Marchiori & Cantoni, 2014; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010).

Arsal, Woosnam, Baldwin, and Backman (2010) pointed out that both potential and current travelers have more trust in peers

than in marketing organizations. They are eager to be engaged in online travel communities mainly as they want to get direct information from experienced travelers who have already been to the tourism destinations. Such information sources are the most influential and preferred ones during the preparation stage of the travel decision-making process. A report by UNWTO (2008) showed that travelers may trust user-generated reviews more than they trust travel agents' content: 20% of respondents said that the websites like TripAdvisor were the most reliable sources of information; only 12% declared that travel agents' own websites were the most reliable, followed by 11% of travelers who chose search engines as a preferred source on travel related information retrieval.

2.2. Destination image versus reputation

Destination image can be generally summarized as: "the perceptions of individual destination attributes ...[and] the holistic impression made by the destination. [It] ... consists of functional characteristics, concerning the more tangible aspects of the destination, and psychological characteristics, concerning the more intangible aspects. Furthermore, [it] ... Can be arranged on a continuum ranging from traits which can be commonly used to compare all destinations to those which are unique to very few destinations" (Echtner & Ritchie, 1993, p. 8). According to Ritchie and Ritchie (1998), and Tasci, Gartner, and Cavusgil (2007), destination image studies find their main application in destination branding analysis, focusing on the way destination managers project destination narratives to customers, and on the way customers perceived those messages to enhance their personal travel experience. However, a standard definition of destination image is far from being established in the tourism research field, and might overlap with related concepts, such as branding and reputation.

Researchers agree that even if destination image is different from destination branding, branding is created through image(s) (Gartner, 1993; Govers & Go, 2009). Conversely, destination image differ from the concept of reputation. A helpful clarification comes from studies in corporate communication in which image and reputation are constructs well-defined as distinct from each other. Reputation is considered the overall attractiveness of the company to all of its constituents, a sort of meta-belief: a belief about belief and evaluations which might help in the absence of direct experience (Fombrun, 1996; Fombrun & Shanley, 1990). From this perspective, image cannot overlap with the reputation of the company, as image is a mental representation of what an individual thinks about a company. On the contrary, reputation is what is narrated about a company among a group of stakeholders. Thus, reputation requires verbalization of the image, and the opinion expressed must be shared among a group of stakeholders (Marchiori & Cantoni, 2014). In this direction, an analysis of the factors influencing destination image formation reveals the basis for the analysis of reputation: studies on attitude determinants in tourism destination choice (Um & Crompton, 1990) argue that external (social stimuli), and internal inputs (personal belief) concur on the formulation of a tourism destination choice at different levels. In particular, reputation can be considered part of the external inputs/social stimuli (Howard & Sheth, 1969) (e.g. word-of-mouth), which can affect the information processing, and in turn the selection of a place to visit. Thus, as it has been underlined by Marchiori and Cantoni (2014), applying those aspects to the online domain it is possible to identify how social stimuli such as electronic word-of-mouth can be represented by online conversations published on social media, with the related research need to better understand their effect on the way a destination is represented online.

2.3. UGC and microblogging in tourism

Apart from online travel communities, other types of social media such as blogs are also perceived as an extensive communication source and an experience-sharing platform for travelers. A sub-category of blogs–microblogs such as Twitter and Weibo, a Chinese equivalent of Twitter, are also well-known and widely-used among travelers globally. Thanks to the technical feature of the microblog that allows a user to write a limited number of words (140 characters both in Twitter and Weibo), travelers can make short comments or brief updates about their trips to inform their families, friends and other “followers”. Instant microblogging could offer the most updated and current information and immediate experience by the travelers as all the comments and updates are spontaneous and reported as they occur (Munar, 2010).

Several researchers have already explored how tourism destinations can be seen from destination-related UGCs. Pan, MacLaurin, and Crotts (2007) analyzed visitors' opinions presented on travel blogs about Charleston (USA) collected from three leading travel blog to gain an understanding of the travel experiences at the destination. De Ascaniis and Morasso (2011) studied UGCs from travel forum posts and reviews using argumentation theory to analyze the reasons why tourists like a destination (Lugano, Switzerland) and to grasp its touristic values on highlighted social media. Inversini et al. (2009) investigated destination-related information in unofficial websites such as blogs, review websites, wikis by querying search engines, and then analyzing topics and arguments from the retrieved results in order to examine the online image of several European destinations. Previous research shows that UGCs as unofficial information resources are of equal importance to the official ones and Destination Management Organizations need to take destination-related UGCs into account when they are creating marketing for their destinations.

2.4. Online communication of Switzerland Tourism

Switzerland Tourism is the national tourism board of Switzerland, whose main purpose is to encourage demand for trips and holidays in the country by foreign and local visitors. Switzerland Tourism is a complex institution whose main aim is to market products and services for Swiss tourism in a given number of countries. Subsequently, it is responsible for the evaluation and the response to the international tourism trends, market analysis as well as design and implementation of promotional campaigns about the country.

Switzerland Tourism embraced all the possibilities that the development of the ICTs and the internet have brought in recent years. In the online market sphere, Switzerland Tourism operates mainly with a website named www.myswitzerland.com. It performs as a hub for all required information that potential clients might look for while preparing their trips to the country (Kalbaska, 2014). The website acts as the central unit for online communication of Switzerland Tourism, enabling marketing and sales activities on the website itself. Moreover, both textual and multimedia content that are present on the main website can be adapted and published on partners' websites and/or distributed via other applications e.g. iPhone applications (Inversini, Brühlhart, & Cantoni, 2012).

Swiss Tourism Office is greatly present on the Chinese market, at the same time representative of Switzerland Tourism on the Chinese market are trying to shape the representations of Chinese tourists on different internet platforms, including Sina Weibo.

2.5. Chinese outbound tourism and social media

The fast growth of Chinese outbound tourism has also seen recently the attention from tourism academics. There are several recent researches on Chinese outbound tourism, ranging from studies of travelers' motivations to investigations of destinations' images. Lu (2011) studied the motivations of Chinese tourists who choose Canada as a potential destination. This study shows that Chinese tourists were attracted by Canada's unique attractions and natural sceneries, high quality of life, and shopping. The main reasons for visiting Canada were prestige, enhancing friendship, exploring opportunities, escape, and novelty. A study from Hua and Yoo (2011) investigated the motivations of potential Chinese tourists who would like to visit the United States for leisure. The study found a significant relationship between travel motivations and socio-demographic factors, such as gender, marital status, and educational background. The authors suggest that a diversification of tourism products is needed when it comes to designing tourism products for Chinese tourists, as they are getting more sophisticated and diverse.

A study about destination's image perceived by Chinese outbound tourists (Li & Stepchenkova, 2012) investigated the mental picture of the United States as a destination among past or potential Chinese long-haul outbound travelers. Results of this study suggested to the representatives of American DMOs to promote attractions that are not yet fully recognized. Moreover, Stepchenkova and Li (2012) analyzed the difference in the image perception among four different groups of Chinese travelers, which are divided according to their previous travel experiences, showing that more experienced groups (which had previous experiences of traveling to the USA or outside Asia) perceived rather abstract and intangible features about the destination, such as open, democratic, and free society. Less experienced groups (which had travel experiences within Asia or only inside China, but were interested in traveling outside of Asia in the nearest future) associated the destination with more tangible objects. Another study (Aramberri & Liang, 2012) analyzed pictures from three leading Chinese travel magazines covering thirteen European destinations in order to find out the depicted destinations' images. France, Italy and Germany are the three most represented countries from the selected magazines, where “pleasant daily life” is seen as the most illustrated subject. Other topics have been investigated, for instance different cultural expectations and visa issues from the perspective of the collaboration between tour operators (e.g. Chinese and British tour operators), and how these matters can affect the actual market development (Sausmarez, Tao, & McGrath, 2012). Tse and Zhang (2013) explored online travel experience sharing by Chinese people, focusing on blogs' and microblogs' posts about Hong Kong as a tourism destination. The study results confirmed that opinions expressed from analyzed blogs and microblogs could identify opportunities to use social media for destination online communication and marketing.

A report by Hu et al. (2013) has analyzed 440 user-generated pictures published by Chinese tourists on Sina Weibo, studying main represented places and object. According to this research, top ten pictured elements were: Mountain with city or village (50 pictures); Lake with city or village (48); Travel brochure, guide book, promotional calendar, advertisement, etc. (44); Swiss flag (flag-like) (39); Buildings, houses, streets (34); Offline promotional activities (24); Pure mountain (23); Chocolate (20); Train, railway system (20); Mountain with lake (13); Skiing (13).

This last report has started to cover a research gap, tackling the image of Switzerland held by Chinese people, and showing how interesting the analysis of UGCs published on a micro-blogging platform can be. The current paper explores the same area of research, focusing on textual elements, instead of pictorial ones.

3. Methodology

In order to provide an inclusive answer to the research question, this study applied both deductive and inductive approaches. A content classification analysis has been performed in order to extract topics and the related sentiment expressed in online conversations about Switzerland published on the microblogging platform Sina Weibo, as well as to generate a categorization matrix of the topics covered online. As confirmed by [Elo and Kyngäs \(2008\)](#), in deductive content analysis, a categorization matrix needs to be built in order to code the data according to the categories, and it is usually based on earlier works, including theories, models, mind maps and literature reviews. Moreover, when the matrix is structured, the researcher could either choose only parts of data that fit the categorization or choose the remaining parts, which do not fit the categorization, in order to generate new concepts based on the principles of inductive content analysis. The dedicated framework used for UGCs classification about tourism destinations proposed by Marchiori et al. has been adopted in this research.

3.1. Sample and data collection

Sina Weibo, a microblogging service, has been chosen in order to collect the sample of UGCs about Switzerland. A recent research by [Resonance China \(2011\)](#) states that Sina Weibo has taken 56.5% of the market share on active users basis in 2011. According to another study Sina Weibo had nearly 240 million users spending on average 11.5 h on it per month ([Resonance China, 2012](#)).

A three-step process has been performed in order to collect UGCs about Switzerland in the microblog:

- *Step 1. Online query and UGCs collection.* Data collection was done by manual querying the internal search engine of Sina Weibo (<http://t.sina.com.cn>). The keywords used for search were “瑞士旅游”, meaning “Switzerland travel”. The search was performed selecting the following timeframe: July 2011 to June 2012, hence one year of posting in the microblog in order to ensure variability and search for communalities in the Chinese perception of Switzerland. As a result, 1415 posts were retrieved.
- *Step 2. Pre-screening content analysis.* All the retrieved posts were analyzed, in order to collect those that involve contents related to traveling in Switzerland. Personal achievement or general questions were considered as not usable, such as “To know detailed information about Switzerland Travel Credit Card from China CITIC Bank, see <http://t.cn/zOpWmD3>”, “I pass the exam to be Switzerland Certified Specialist”, “Is anybody going to travel to Switzerland this October?” or “I need a guide who speaks Chinese when I travel to Switzerland this September”, “Tourism management schools are very popular in Switzerland...”. The pre-screening content analysis resulted in 732 (51.7%) microblog posts that were considered as usable for the topic and sentiment analysis.
- *Step 3. Analysis of the topic and sentiment expressed in the posts.* Each post was categorized according to the five tourism destination topic dimensions identified in the adopted content analysis framework: Society; Governance; Environment; Performance; Products and Services (with their related subcategories: Accommodation, Food & Beverage, Site attractions, Outdoor activities, Events, Entertainments, Transportation, Infrastructure and Other).

The prominent topic(s) expressed within each post were coded with one or more (up to three) of the abovementioned topic dimensions. New topic categories were generated if necessary. At the

same time, the expressed sentiment of every post was evaluated following a five-points Likert scale: where 1 – negative feelings expressed; 5 – positive feelings expressed. The code was indicated as not applicable where feelings were not expressed.

Additionally, coders were asked to indicate if the author of the post had a direct experience with Switzerland (e.g. visited Switzerland previously) or indirect experience (e.g. willing to visit Switzerland in the future).

All posts were collected in Mandarin Chinese, and then translated in English in order to report the analysis, and back translated for validity. Inter-coder reliability between two coders has been calculated using ReCal2 ([Freelon, 2010](#)), obtaining a Krippendorff's alpha value –0.026 (percentage of agreement of 90%), resulting in a high level of inter-coder agreement ([Lombard, Snyder-Duch, & Campanella Bracken 2010](#)).

4. Results

Among the 732 posts analyzed, 141 (19%) have been associated to more than one topic driver/category. Thus, the total occurrence of all drivers resulted 873 times.

Some drivers were more acknowledged than others, namely *d1 – destination offers a satisfying tourism product*, with 68 posts; *d2 – destination offers a pleasant atmosphere*, with 115 posts; *d14 – destination offers a satisfying tourism experience*, with 69 posts. [Table 1](#) presents an overview of all results, including sentiment expressed, which got an average score of 4.6 out of 5.0 from a total of 526 posts expressing a sentiment.

Four new categories emerged during the analysis: *Travel phenomena & stories*, *Willingness to go*, *Effective official communication*, and *Link sharing*. These new categories might help to refine the framework proposed by Marchiori and Cantoni.

The category *Travel phenomena & stories* resulted from the posts where users narrating about tourists' behavior and stories they have heard from others, who mentioned Switzerland as a tourism destination or traveling in Switzerland (e.g. the behavior of Chinese tourists in Switzerland) but not mentioning any of the five dimensions. Example of a post within this category can be the next one: “I see Chinese characters (on the widow of the shop)! It seems that there are many Chinese coming to Zurich for traveling and shopping (near the lake of Zurich)”.

The category *Willingness to go* resulted from the posts in which users stated their desire of visiting Switzerland, using expressions like: “Last night I dreamed traveling to Switzerland. I was really gloomy when I woke up”.

The category *Effective official communication* resulted from the posts where users commented on marketing campaigns promoted by the Swiss Tourism Office in China (Beijing) on the microblog platform. Indeed, users seemed to be particularly impressed by the interaction with the official institution and they also found themselves engaged, responding with many positive feedbacks, such as: “The Swiss Tourism Office is so effective”, “I wish I could win this prize so I can go to visit Switzerland to realize my dream”.

The *Link sharing* category resulted from the posts where users shared information sources about where to find travel information related to Switzerland, including blogs, travel package offers, news, mostly with a link to the URL where the information is located. For instance: “The best post about travel to Switzerland <http://t.cn/ajsUvA>”.

The main topic dimensions were Products and services, followed by Travel phenomena and stories, Willingness to go, Effective Official Communication and Performance. A description of the contents' peculiarities of each category is presented further.

Table 1

Overview of sentiment expressed by posts.

Five main tourism destination-related thematic dimensions

Dimensions	Code – drivers	#	Sentiment expressed evaluation		
			Average sentiment expressed ^a	Posts expressing sentiment	Posts without sentiment ^b
Products and services	d1 – Destination offers a satisfying tourism product	267	4.8	52	16
	d2 – D. offers a pleasant atmosphere		4.8	94	21
	d3 – D. offers products and services that are good value for money		3.8	19	15
	d4 – D. presents accurate information of their products and services		4.9	11	39
Society	d5 – D. offers interesting local culture and traditions	11	5.0	4	1
	d6 – D. has hospitable residents		4.7	6	0
Governance	d7 – D. tourism industry and organizations cooperate and interact	9	5.0	1	1
	d8 – D. presents innovative and/or improved products and services		5.0	1	6
Environment	d9 – D. has a high eco-awareness	26	5.0	4	3
	d10 – Has a favorable weather		3.9	7	7
	d11 – D. offers a safe environment		4.0	2	3
Performance	d12 – D. presents an accurate image	116	5.0	30	11
	d13 – D. meets my expectation		3.0	6	0
	d14 – D. offers a satisfying tourism experience		4.8	64	5
New categories					
Travel phenomena and stories	d15 – The user talks about tourist' behaviors, stories involved the D.	129	5.0	23	106
Willingness to go	d16 – The user wishes to visit the D.	128	5.0	128	0
Official communication	d17 – The destination has a good official communication	122	5.0	67	55
Link sharing	d18 – The user shares information related to the D.	65	4.6	7	58

^a Scale: from 1 = negative feelings expressed to 5 = positive feelings expressed.^b Not applicable or no feeling expressed in a post.

4.1. Products and services

This dimension has the highest number of occurrences: 267; the following distribution of its subcategories can be seen. *Site Attractions* is the leading sub-category, counting for 42.7%. The majority of the posts under this sub-category focused on the offered pleasant atmosphere, and praised about the beauty of the sceneries, including mountains, lakes and other natural attractions. Luzern and the Alps area were the most quoted attractions. Examples of analyzed posts are: “Luzern is the most beautiful and ideal city in Switzerland and it is a must-go place for traveling in Switzerland”, “The Alps form the most attractive scenery in Switzerland”. It has to be noted that in the adopted model, places are subsumed within products and services because the model was mapped onto corporate reputation/branding approaches, then considering places themselves as a major part of what a destination can offer to tourists.

Food & Beverage accounts for 16.1%. In particular, “chocolate” and “cheese” resulted as the most quoted topics. Example of posts are: “I love to eat Frey's black chocolate and always finish an entire bar by myself”, “If you travel to Switzerland, the tasty food you have to try is the cheese fondue”.

Transportation accounts for 15.3%. Several posts were related to the Swiss public transportation system, and tourists gave

compliments particularly to the Swiss railway system for its punctuality and overall performance. Moreover, the “Swiss Pass” (i.e. the all-in-one ticket to travel by rail in Switzerland), resulted highly appreciated among the tourists who organized the trips by themselves, leaving posts such as: “Swiss Pass is an indispensable tool for traveling in Switzerland.”

Other sub-category counts for 9.7%, within which it was possible to identify specific topics, such as: posts related to souvenirs (either buying souvenirs in Switzerland or receiving souvenirs bought from Switzerland) and shopping. Among those posts, only 15 provided a sentiment expressed, which was mainly positive about the good quality of the products (e.g. “Speaking about Switzerland, there are at least two things you have to know; one is the Swiss knife, another is Swiss-made watches. It will always be a good choice if you bring these two as souvenirs”). Overall, there were 3 only posts about the high price of goods and services in Switzerland expressed with negative feelings.

Outdoor Activities account for 5.9% and the mostly mentioned outdoor activity was skiing (e.g. “Skiing on the Alps is a must-do for tourists traveling in Switzerland; the relationship between Swiss and skiing is like the ones between Brazilian and football, Chinese and table tennis. The Alps have turned Switzerland into a paradise for skiing”), followed by a few mentioning about paragliding and hiking.

Subcategories as *Accommodation*, *Events*, *Infrastructure* and *Entertainment* are much less mentioned. Regarding sentiment evaluation, there were few negative feelings expressed about the price of a hotel, which was considered not reasonable in comparison to its old condition. Other complaints were about the availability of public toilets.

4.2. Travel phenomena and stories

Posts gathered in this category (129 occurrences in total) covered mainly: (a) stories that users experienced by themselves or they have heard from friends, families and relatives when they traveled in Switzerland. Example of this type of topic is: “. . . my dad suddenly took out a big piece of stone, I asked where it is from and he said he picked it up days ago on the Alps when he was traveling in Switzerland. . . me and my mom burst into laugh. . .”; (b) messages that users published or read elsewhere and reposted on Sina Weibo. Example: “I just published a blog article ‘Travel in Europe – Switzerland: Interlaken, Jungfrau’ – Throughout the entire process, the rain and the clouds were gone on the second day when we arrived to Switzerland. It was sunny all the way and we were super lucky. Usually travel groups will go up to Jungfrau and Titlis, and we have chosen Jungfrau”; (c) travel schedule to Switzerland.

Among the posts with a sentiment expressed, the sentiments were only positive.

4.3. Willingness to go

The category *Willingness to go* emerged from the content analysis due to the presence of several wishes from Weibo users, who stated their desire to visit this European country; in total, this category has got 128 occurrences. In particular, several posts were related to a campaign initiated by the Swiss Tourism Office in Beijing. The campaign referred to the Swiss initiative “Switzerland, at your fingertips”, which combined both online and offline promotional activities. Therefore, in Weibo, users posted comments about this campaign, and also reported related offline activities. Users who participated in the campaign were highly involved (the campaign was asking to use stickers to create Swiss flag-like shapes, and post their images on Weibo). Great attention has been paid to the campaign upon Weibo. Some users who had been to Switzerland expressed their wishes for visiting again, like “. . . I had a trip in Switzerland in 2007 for a total of 45 days and still I felt the fun is far from enough. Each time when I was talking about this experience, I felt like I was telling a fairy tale. I have been always paying attention to Switzerland and expecting I could walk into this fairy tale-like world once again. . .”. Other examples: “#Switzerland, at your fingertips# I have been longing for traveling to Switzerland, hope I can make it this time!”, “It is a promotion on the street from the Swiss Tourism Office. [with photo attached] It’s very well organized, the earth is fully covered with ground barks and there is cheese-making on the spot. I really want to go to Switzerland.” All 128 posts expressed positive sentiments.

4.4. Effective official communication

All posts in this category – which got 122 occurrences – can be seen as positive results of the official communication. This category emerged from the content analysis due to the presence of considerable number of comments about the activities of the Swiss Tourism Office in China, which has an official account on Sina Weibo. Swiss Tourism Office has been particularly active in the microblog platform, commenting on activities of the online campaigns that were conducted together with various travel agencies on all kinds of themes in different tourism-related fairs and conferences. Users of Sina Weibo were very much engaged within the interaction,

posting with positive feedbacks and statements, such as: “The Swiss Tourism Office is so effective”, “I am so glad that I come here to participate in this event”.

4.5. Performance

Performance dimension resulted with 116 occurrences. The majority of the posts were related to *d14 – destination offers a satisfying tourism experience*, followed by *d12 – destination presents an accurate image*, and few posts mentioned *d13 – destination meets my expectations*. The majority of tourists declared to be satisfied with their traveling experience in Switzerland, underlying good memories of their trips, such as: “This morning I read an article about travel to Switzerland, that I remember I did last year. I am really pleased that I visited Switzerland . . . it was really a rare opportunity . . . I missed every city that we have been there together. . .”.

4.6. Link sharing

The category *Link sharing* emerged from the content analysis due to the presence of several links shared among the users without any comment or opinion (in total 65 occurrences). It was possible to infer an overall positive tone of the shared link, as the contents of the links were mainly:

- travel package offers, such as “28th of January, 2011, 4 days trip in Switzerland. The first travel season of Spring Festival begins! The most classical ‘golden route’ of traveling in Switzerland: Château de Chillon, Geneva, Zermatt, Matterhorn, Évian, Bern (the capital city), Zurich, Luzern. It is a trip of fairy tales and full of surprises. The trip starts with happiness as soon as the group reaches 4 people!!”
- sharing news, such as “China has become Switzerland’s biggest target market in Asia” Mr. Simon Bosshart, the director of the Asian-pacific region of Swiss Tourism Office said.
- sharing webpages, such as “A detailed walk-through for traveling to Switzerland. <http://t.cn/apWdMb>.”

4.7. Main topics

The following four specific topic assumptions have emerged from the content analysis of the microblog posts on Sino Weibo:

- *Effective online and offline official communication*. The official communication offered by the Swiss Tourism Office in China has been evaluated by users as an effective one. There were several posts referring to different online campaigns as well as to its diverse offline promotional activities. Weibo users actively take part in the online campaign, posting about offline promotions. It can be interpreted that there is a thoroughly organized online marketing and communication strategy by the Swiss Tourism Office in China.
- *Prospective travelers*. There is a clear willingness expressed from Weibo users to visit Switzerland for their vacation. The large number of online promotional campaign participants also confirms that Weibo users would love to win an opportunities to get a trip to Switzerland. This could prove that Switzerland is one of most favored and attractive tourism destinations for the Mainland Chinese.
- *Site attractions*. Swiss cities like Luzern, Zurich, Interlaken, Zermatt and Geneva, site attractions like the Chapel Bridge over the lake of Luzern with urban area around, the face of Matterhorn mountain seen from Zermatt, etc. appeared in the online conversations more often than others.
- *Shopping in Switzerland is not an outstanding topic*. Shopping-related posts were not as manifested as what has been reported

in other studies (China Internet Watch, 2012). The authors would offer an explanation to this contradiction from a privacy perspective: Chinese people now learn to be very cautious about publishing personal information online; posts on *Sina Weibo* are of very high exposure to the public and users might not be willing to display their properties on an open social network.

5. Conclusions and discussions

Results gathered from the investigation of the online representation of Switzerland as a tourism destination in the Chinese microblogging platform *Sina Weibo* demonstrated the presence of active online conversations about traveling to Switzerland. Such data are not only to be considered a further evidence of the interest for Switzerland by Chinese people, as suggested by the recent literature, but also as a map of contents and issues that are likely to be found by Chinese prospects who search for information on Switzerland as a tourism destination. In fact, as proposed by recent reports by China Travel Trends, China Outbound Tourism Research Institute, and Asia Pacific Travel Association, Chinese travelers are more likely to get their information through social media rather than visiting official websites.

Findings from this exploratory study encourage research toward the investigation of the value of UGCs in microblogging platforms as a proper source of information, to be further explored in order to learn about tourism destinations' online representation in a specific geographical, cultural and social context, like the Chinese one.

Among the microblog posts analyzed, *Products & Services* resulted as the most mentioned topic dimension, within which *Site attractions* was the most relevant sub-category, together with the related sub-category "*the destination offers a pleasant atmosphere*". Four new categories: *Travel phenomena & stories*, *Willingness to go*, *Effective official communication* and *Link sharing*, emerged from the content analysis, providing new insights for a possible extension of the topic dimensions model used for this study.

The analysis of the posts published on *Sina Weibo* has revealed how Chinese-speaking users are keen to: (i) discuss stories they have heard from others about traveling to Switzerland; (ii) express their desire to visit Switzerland; (iii) pay attention to the destination's official promotion; and (iv) share information sources and links about Switzerland from other blogs and websites. Besides, the average sentiment expressed toward Switzerland as a tourism destination resulted as highly positive.

As it has been stressed at the very beginning, this study is a first exploratory one, aiming to open a promising research venue, due to this, it has some limitations that are to be mentioned hereafter.

First of all, the coding activity entailed always a margin of subjective evaluation, as: "coding decisions should be made from information available in the coded message only" (Neuendorf, 2002, p. 133).

A second limitation of this study concerns the range of collected data, which was limited to the microblog text posts (not considering posted images), as well as the range of keywords used, when other keywords might have provided further relevant data.

A third limitation is closely connected with the exploratory nature of this study, whose main goal was to provide a proof of concept of the used method, rather than an extensive interpretation of found data: we believe that such extensive interpretation might be done by further studies, applying also additional disciplinary tools.

Future research could be extended to include posted images, or to other types of UGCs from travel blogs and reviews; and might integrate more focused aspects. Moreover, a comparison between the results gathered from the *Sina Weibo* analysis and focus groups/online survey investigation on the same topic, could be done in order to better understand particularities of the *Sina*

Weibo audience and the overall representation of Switzerland in the Chinese market.

Nevertheless, this study contributes to the research field of tourism destination online representation and image, providing evidence to the role of online conversations shaped in a microblogging platform.

Managers in charge of promoting a tourism destination can benefit from this research. In particular, DMOs that need to define official communication strategies for their destinations in the Chinese online domain can consider including the microblogging platform as a powerful source of information for the investigation of the online representation. DMOs can also benefit from the use of a microblogging platform as a direct channel for an informal and direct/immediate way to establish relationship with Chinese tourists and potential tourists as they are resulted particularly responsive to official communications and marketing initiatives. The microblog *Sina Weibo* resulted to be a particularly effective tool for reaching Mainland Chinese tourists by Swiss Tourism. Indeed, DMOs could get in touch directly with the users who express their willingness to visit and make use of positive user-generated contents from those users who already visited the destination in order to create a more engaging communication and marketing path.

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